

## » WTC STRUCTURE POINTS TO PONDER



**Match disparity:** Table-topper South Africa played just 12 Tests in the 2023–25 cycle, the joint-lowest with Bangladesh, while England featured in 22 matches in the same timeframe. AFP

# UNEVEN SERIES, UNEQUAL CHANCES: WTC'S STRUCTURAL PROBLEM

South Africa's WTC run **sparks debate** on whether the tournament's structure rewards the best team or the best schedule.

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**W**hen South Africa challenges Australia for the World Test Championship (WTC) mace at Lord's from June 11, the spectacle could serve as a touchstone of the competition's fairness and point towards what lies in store for the oldest format of the game.

The Proteas' run to their maiden

WTC final has drawn scrutiny with regards to the format of the tournament, and questions have been raised about whether they are worthy of facing the defending champion in the Ultimate Test.

They head into the summit clash on the back of six consecutive wins — two each against lower-ranked Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Pakistan. Add to that the 1-0 series win in the West Indies in August last year, and South Africa's last four opponents in the current WTC cycle comprise the

bottom-placed teams in the standings. What preceded South Africa's eight-match unbeaten streak is perhaps what makes its appearance in the final seem ironic to some. In what was considered a blasphemous snub to Test cricket, South Africa named an understrength 14-member squad for the two-match series in New Zealand, which included as many as six uncapped players. The touring party was led by an uncapped skipper, and its most experienced member had